

It Runneth Over

By the time this is read, we will all have stars in our eyes. Stars wearing boots riveted with studs that both grip and tear. They will run, slide, even dive, in a billion-dollar event, on whose foundation rests many a multinational bottom. Sorry, that should read bottom line. Just as this giant-size Cup tips over, some smaller stories should be heard. About recognition and about legacy, a word now repeatedly flogged by mega-event bidders and sellers as camouflage for the unhappy leftovers of billion-dollar spends. The 2010 Commonwealth Games in Delhi promise many such legacies.

South Africa, though, seems to know what it is doing. Whenever something big happens in its sport, the Rainbow nation falls in love and shows off its heart. Like it did in at the 1995 Rugby World Cup or the African Nations Cup a year later. Exhibit A for South Africa's football World Cup is its centrepiece Soccer City stadium. Last month, the 200 workers who had built the venue, construction workers, cleaners, were given two free tickets each, the organisers saying to them, "Today we recognise your contribution."

A total of 54,000 tickets will be given to those involved in upgradation or construction of the World Cup venues. It may just look like a brownie-gathering corporate social responsibility gesture, but it is one whose resonance is powerful and will last longer than the laser shows of opening ceremonies. Is Delhi 2010 listening? Or learning?

Then there is 'legacy'. Yes, South Africa's new football grounds will be used in the future. Yes, the cable car-accessible viewing platform of the arch over the Moses Mabhida Stadium will fast become a Durban tourist attraction. But as the world now fuses about South Africa's crime figures, its very air seems a little changed.

When Pretoria's Loftus Versfeld Stadium, among the world's most famous rugby grounds, was being refurbished for the Cup, its home team the Blue Bulls was forced to move two games. The closest venue of appropriate size was a football ground

called Orlando Stadium. Except it was in Soweto, the fortress of the anti-apartheid movement of the past.

South Africa's white sport, rugby, was made to join hands with its black sport, football. The Bull's fans, mostly Afrikaaner, did make their trip in slightly nervous numbers. In response Sowetans opened up their bars, front yards and neighbourhood streets to welcome them. A dazed Bulls fan told a newspaper, "This is the biggest transformational event in South Africa except for Mandela leading the country."

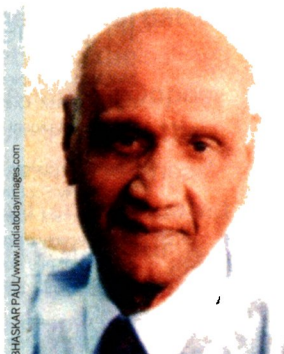
All this 10 days before the Cup. Now that is real legacy. So, enjoy the footy and never forget that this World Cup is being played in a country where magic is possible.



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SIGNPOSTS

DIED: **Stya Paul**, 91, freedom fighter and educationist who founded the Apeejay Education Society. He

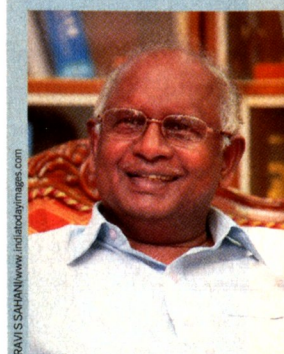


was jailed during the 1942 Quit India Movement. He was the elder brother of London-based NRI Lord Swraj Paul.

WON: By the national women's badminton champion **Trupti Murgunde**, the Maldives Open singles title. **Anand Pawar** won the men's singles event.

DIED: **Prabhakar Krishna Kamat** aka Joe, who played Ranji Trophy cricket for Mumbai during the 1950s. He was 81.

APPOINTED: Former chief justice of India **K.G. Balakrishnan** as the sixth chairman of the National Human Rights Commission.



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